TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Report Writing

The report defined and classified — its standard structure from title page to appendices, the qualities of a good report, and a model skeleton for a factory inspection report.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 9 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. What a report is

A **report** is an orderly, factual account of an event, activity, investigation or state of affairs, prepared for a definite reader and a definite purpose, usually ending in conclusions and, where asked, recommendations. Its marks against neighbouring forms: it is based on **collected facts** (not opinion or imagination), it is **structured by headings** rather than flowing as an essay, it looks **backward** at what has happened or been found (a proposal, Topic 10, looks forward), and it is written **because someone commissioned it** — a superior, a committee, a buyer. Reports are the upward communication of Topic 5 in their most developed form: production reports, inspection reports, test reports and accident reports are the paper trail of every mill.

2. Types of reports

TYPE	CHARACTER AND EXAMPLES
Routine / periodic reports	Prepared at fixed intervals in a fixed form — daily production report, monthly stock return. Mostly tabulated facts, brief comment.
Special reports	Commissioned for one occasion — a new machine’s trial, a market survey, a feasibility study.
Inspection reports	Record of an examination made on the spot — fabric inspection, building or safety inspection — listing condition found against a standard.
Investigation reports	Into a problem or incident — an accident inquiry, a complaint investigation — establishing causes and responsibility, usually with recommendations.
Technical / laboratory reports	Test methods, results and interpretation — the GSM and shrinkage report, the fastness test report: data first, conclusion tied to the data.

3. The structure of a formal report

PART	FUNCTION
Title page	Title of the report, author, authority commissioning it, date — the report's identity.
Contents	List of sections with page numbers (for longer reports).
Summary / abstract	The whole report in a paragraph: what was examined, what was found, what is recommended. Busy readers read this and the recommendations only — write it last and write it well.
Introduction / terms of reference	Who commissioned the report, its scope and limits, and the method of collecting facts (visits, tests, records examined).
Findings (the body)	The facts, organised under headings in logical order, with tables and figures where they carry the facts better than sentences. Facts and comment kept distinguishable.
Conclusions	What the findings mean — the deductions, numbered if several, each traceable to the findings.
Recommendations	The actions proposed, numbered, specific and feasible, following from the conclusions. (Not every report is asked for them; an inspection report may end at findings.)
Appendices	Supporting material too bulky for the body — raw data, test sheets, photographs, drawings.
Signature and date	The author signs: a report is a responsibility, not an anonymous paper.

Short reports (one to three pages) compress the same skeleton into memo form: heading block (To / From / Date / Subject), purpose in one line, findings, conclusion, recommendation — the structure survives the shrinking.

4. A model skeleton (short inspection report)

REPORT ON THE INSPECTION OF FINISHED KNIT FABRIC, LOT 118
To: General Manager (Production) · From: Quality Control Manager · Date: 12 November 2026

1. Purpose. At your instruction of 10 November, the undersigned inspected Lot 118 (single jersey, 5,000 kg) before dispatch to the buyer.
2. Method. Twenty rolls (10% of the lot) were inspected on the inspection machine under standard lighting; faults were recorded per 100 square yards.
3. Findings. (i) Total fault points averaged 18 per 100 sq. yd., within the buyer's limit of 20. (ii) Two

rolls showed oil stains at the selvedge. (iii) GSM measured 158 against the specified 160 ± 5% — within tolerance.
4. Conclusion. The lot meets the buyer's standard except for the two oil-stained rolls.
5. Recommendation. The two rolls be withheld and re-finished; the remainder be released for dispatch.

(signature) — Quality Control Manager

5. Qualities of a good report

- **Accuracy** — facts verified; figures checked; nothing asserted beyond the evidence.
- **Objectivity** — the reporter reports; personal feeling and blame stay out of the findings.
- **Clarity and logical order** — headings that mirror the reader's questions; one topic per section.
- **Brevity with completeness** — the seven C's of Topic 8 applied to a longer instrument.
- **Reader-fit** — technical depth matched to its commissioning reader; a director's summary style for directors, full data for engineers.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Terms of reference	The commissioning statement of a report's scope, purpose and limits.
Findings	The facts established by the report's inquiry, organised under headings.
Appendix	Supporting material placed after the main text of a report.
Abstract / summary	A condensed statement of the report's inquiry, findings and recommendations.
Feasibility study	A special report examining whether a proposed project can succeed.

7. Key points and summary

- A report is a commissioned, factual, structured account looking backward — classified as routine, special, inspection, investigation or technical.
- Its skeleton: title, contents, summary, introduction/terms of reference, findings, conclusions, recommendations, appendices, signature — compressible into memo form without losing the logic.
- Quality = accuracy, objectivity, clarity, proportionate brevity, and fit to the commissioning reader.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Define a report and distinguish it from (a) an essay and (b) a proposal.
2. Classify: a daily production return; an inquiry into a boiler accident; a GSM test sheet with interpretation; a one-off study of a new market. Name the type of each.
3. List the parts of a formal report in order and give the function of the terms of reference.
4. Why is the summary written last although it stands first?
5. Draft the findings and recommendation sections (model format) for a short report: “Inspection of hostel water supply” — invent three findings clearly marked as practice data.
6. A report’s findings say a machine is “in very bad condition and the fitter is careless.” Rewrite the sentence to satisfy objectivity and concreteness.
7. When may a report properly end without recommendations?

Answer key

1. A report is an orderly factual account of an inquiry or state of affairs, commissioned for a definite purpose and reader. (a) An essay develops its author’s views in continuous prose; a report presents collected facts under headings for a decision-maker. (b) A proposal argues for future action and seeks approval to begin; a report records what has been examined or has happened.
2. Daily production return — routine/periodic. Boiler accident inquiry — investigation. GSM test with interpretation — technical/laboratory. New-market study — special (feasibility/market) report.
3. Title page; contents; summary; introduction/terms of reference; findings; conclusions; recommendations; appendices; signature and date. Terms of reference state who commissioned the report, its scope and its limits — the contract the findings must fulfil.
4. Because it condenses the finished findings and recommendations; written first, it would promise conclusions the inquiry has not yet reached. Placed first because most readers read it first.
5. Model shape — Findings: (i) overhead tank last cleaned (practice data) four months ago; (ii) two of six taps show low flow; (iii) water sample reported within standard by the laboratory (practice data). Recommendation: tank cleaning be scheduled half-yearly and the two taps’ filters replaced this week. The marks are for structure, separation of fact and action, and honest practice-data framing.
6. “The machine’s output on 10–12 November was 22% below its standard rate; bearing temperature readings exceeded the maker’s limit on all three days; the maintenance log shows no lubrication entry for the past 19 days.” — facts and figures replace judgement, and responsibility is left to conclusions drawn from them.

7. When its terms of reference ask only for facts — a pure inspection or information report — or where action belongs to a different authority; the report then ends at findings/conclusions, and may note that recommendations were not called for.
